

What is justice?

This question breaks down into a number of sub-questions. We can ask what it means for a **person** to be just. We can also ask what it means for an **international system** of distinct societies to be just.

Today we are going to focus on the question of what it means for an individual society — which for our purposes we can take to be a nation — to be just.

This question is sometimes called the question of **distributive justice**, because it asks about the just distribution of goods within a society at a time.

What goods are we talking about?

One category is what we might call **material goods**. These include things like food and property and income.

But these are not the only goods. Other goods include **political rights** (such as the right to vote) and **liberties** (such as the freedom to choose where one lives or whom one marries or what job one pursues). As we will see, there are others.

This is enough to describe a society which most of us would agree
to be unjust.

At some initial time t , the members of a society are living in a state of relative equality. But at a later time $t+1$, some sub-group A takes all of the property of sub-group B. Group A consolidates its power, and enslaves the members of group B, depriving them by force of their political rights and liberties (such as freedom of association and the freedom to pursue an education). By time $t+2$, group A owns all of the property, and gives members of group B only the minimum needed for survival. Members of group B are only permitted to serve group A in the ways that members of group A direct.

It is universal that, at $t+2$, this is an unjust society.

The interesting question is: why is this? What would have to be different for this to be a just society? Different theories of justice provide different answers to this question.

Our first theory of justice provides a very straightforward answer to this question. On this view, what is unjust about our imagined society is its **inequality**. On this view, a just society is one in which goods are distributed equally. This view is called **egalitarianism**.

What would it mean for goods to be distributed equally? A simple answer would be that everyone gets exactly the same goods. Everyone gets just the same food, just the same kind of residence, etc.

But if you think about it, this wouldn't be an ideal set-up. Suppose that I love broccoli and hate spinach, and you are the reverse. Wouldn't it be better for me to get more broccoli and less spinach, and for you to get more spinach and less broccoli? And yet this would seem to be unjust on our simple egalitarian view.

The natural response to this on behalf of the egalitarian is to say that an equal distribution of goods need not mean that we each get exactly the same goods. Instead, perhaps we each should get exactly the same opportunity to buy goods. In a society like ours, this would mean that we would each get the same amount of **money** and the same **income**. I could then use this money on broccoli, and you could use it on spinach. The fact that we made different choices would not make the distribution of goods unequal.

A second problem for the egalitarian is the problem of how to handle inequalities that emerge over time.

Even if we specify that you and I get the same income at every period in our lives, we might still end up with very unequal distributions of goods. I might be very wasteful with my resources whereas you might be very clever with yours, so that after 20 years you have accumulated a large amount of resources. Or maybe my house was destroyed by a tornado, and yours was not.

This leads to a question for the egalitarian. How should we respond to situations in which inequalities in wealth and income develop over time?

The problem is exacerbated if we think about families. Suppose that you are clever with your resources and want to pass them along to your children, whereas I give my children nothing. Then it looks like your children will have much greater resources than mine from the start. Obviously over a number of generations, the difference might become vast.

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